

**This Patient Group Direction (PGD) is intended only for registered healthcare professionals who have been named and authorised by their organisation to practice under it.**

Patient Group Direction  
for the administration of Varivax and Varilrix for vaccination against Chickenpox

## Summary of NICE and NICE CKS Guidelines for Chickenpox (Varicella) Vaccination

### *Vaccine Overview*

- The varicella (chickenpox) vaccine is a **live attenuated vaccine**.
- Two licensed brands in the UK: **VARIVAX®** and **VARILRIX®**.
- Typically administered **subcutaneously**, but **intramuscular** administration is also acceptable if necessary.

### *Indications for Vaccination*

The varicella vaccine is recommended for:

1. **Susceptible healthcare workers** and those in contact with immunocompromised individuals (to prevent transmission).
2. **Susceptible close household contacts** of immunocompromised patients.
3. **Non-immune adults and adolescents** (13 years and older) with no history of chickenpox, especially women of childbearing age (with appropriate contraceptive advice).
4. **Susceptible children (over 12 months)** who are at high risk of severe chickenpox or pose a risk to vulnerable contacts.
5. **Outbreak control** in some institutional settings (e.g. schools, nurseries, hospitals).

Note: "Susceptible" = no reliable history of chickenpox or no evidence of immunity.

### *Dosing Schedule*

- **Two doses** are required for full protection:
  - **First dose** at any time from 12 months of age.
  - **Second dose** given at least **4 to 8 weeks later**.
- If given as part of MMRV combination vaccine, different guidance may apply for under-2s (due to febrile seizure risk).

### *Contraindications*

Do **not** administer the vaccine to:

- Individuals with a history of severe allergic reaction to a previous varicella vaccine dose or any component.
- Immunosuppressed individuals (unless under specialist advice).
- Pregnant women (and advise avoiding pregnancy for **at least 1 month** after vaccination).
- People with untreated active tuberculosis or current febrile illness requiring postponement.

### *Precautions*

- Postpone in acute illness with fever.
- Avoid salicylates (e.g. aspirin) for 6 weeks after vaccination due to Reye's syndrome risk.
- Consider prior immunity testing in adults if uncertain.

### *Vaccine Effectiveness*

- Two doses are about **90–95% effective** at preventing chickenpox.
- If breakthrough infection occurs, it is usually mild.

### *Adverse Effects*

- Common: Local site reactions, mild fever, mild rash.
- Rare: Febrile seizures (especially with MMRV in <2 years), varicella-like rash, mild systemic symptoms.

### *Documentation and Reporting*

- Record batch number, site of injection, and date.
- Report any adverse reactions via **Yellow Card Scheme**.

# Patient Group Direction

for the supply/administration of

*Varivax*

for vaccination against

*Chickenpox*

## ***Healthcare professionals covered and training***

|                                       | Healthcare professionals allowed to work under this PGD and requirements                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|---------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Qualifications and Registration       | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>● Pharmacist registered and practicing with the GPhC</li> <li>● Pharmacy technician registered and practicing with the GPhC</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Training and assessment               | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>● Pharmacists and Pharmacy Technicians must have completed training relevant to this condition to use this PGD. This training will be documented and overseen by the Get Real Health team.</li> <li>● All users must be familiar with the SPC for the products as well as BNF advice and any applicable national guidelines</li> <li>● All users must previously have used PGD's to supply medication</li> <li>● Must work in compliance with the SOPs of their own employer</li> <li>● All users must have appropriate indemnity in place to cover this service</li> </ul> |
| Further training and responsibilities | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>● All users must be up to date with CPD requirements and appraisal</li> <li>● All users must be up to date with MHRA and safety alerts with regards to medical products</li> <li>● All users must understand the concepts of capacity and consent and be aware of the Mental Capacity Act 2005.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |

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|------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| PGD Indication                                       | Active immunisation against varicella (chickenpox) in individuals aged 12 months and over who are susceptible to the varicella-zoster virus and have no history of chickenpox infection or prior vaccination.                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| Inclusion criteria                                   | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>- Individuals aged 12 months and older.</li> <li>- No history of chickenpox infection.</li> <li>- No previous varicella vaccination.</li> <li>- Informed consent given.</li> <li>- Suitable for vaccination in accordance with national immunisation guidelines.</li> </ul>                                                                                                          |
| Exclusion criteria                                   | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>- History of chickenpox infection.</li> <li>- Previous varicella vaccination.</li> <li>- Hypersensitivity to neomycin, gelatin, or any component of the vaccine.</li> <li>- Immunocompromised individuals unless under specialist advice.</li> <li>- Pregnancy or planning pregnancy within one month.</li> <li>- Acute febrile illness or active untreated tuberculosis.</li> </ul> |
| Cautions                                             | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>- Avoid contact with high-risk individuals (e.g. immunosuppressed) for 4–6 weeks if a rash develops post-vaccination.</li> <li>- Pregnancy must be avoided for one month post-vaccination.</li> <li>- Postpone in the case of moderate or severe illness with fever.</li> <li>- Consider delaying vaccination if the individual received blood products recently.</li> </ul>         |
| Actions if patient is excluded or declines treatment | Advise on alternative treatment options and how these can be accessed. Document any advice given and the decision reached. Inform or refer to the GP as appropriate                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |

### *Details of the medicine*

|                                             |                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|---------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Name, form and strength of medicine         | Varivax                                                                                                                                                                          |
| Legal category                              | POM                                                                                                                                                                              |
| Storage                                     | Store in a refrigerator (2°C–8°C). Do not freeze. Protect from light.                                                                                                            |
| Route/method of administration              | Subcutaneous injection, usually in the upper arm.                                                                                                                                |
| Dose and frequency                          | Single 0.5 mL dose. A second dose may be given after at least 4 weeks if needed.                                                                                                 |
| Quantity to be administered and/or supplied | Single 0.5ml dose                                                                                                                                                                |
| Maximum or minimum treatment period         | One or two doses depending on immune status and age group.                                                                                                                       |
| Adverse effects                             | Injection site reactions (pain, redness, swelling), fever, rash, irritability, or upper respiratory symptoms. Rarely, varicella-like rash or febrile convulsions. Refer to SmPC. |

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| Yellow card reporting | Report any suspected adverse effects via <a href="https://yellowcard.mhra.gov.uk">https://yellowcard.mhra.gov.uk</a> and notify the GP as appropriate.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| Records to be kept    | <p>Record the following information:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>● that valid informed consent was given</li> <li>● name of individual, address, date of birth and GP</li> <li>● name of healthcare practitioner</li> <li>● name and brand of medication</li> <li>● date of supply dose, form and route quantity supplied</li> <li>● advice given, including advice given if excluded or declines treatment</li> <li>● details of any adverse drug reactions and actions taken supplied via PGD</li> </ul> <p>Records should be signed and dated. All records should be clear, legible and contemporaneous. Electronic records can be made.</p> <p>A record of all individuals receiving treatment under this PGD should also be kept for audit purposes as follows:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>● Adults aged 18 years and over - keep records for 8 years</li> <li>● Children aged under 18 years -keep records until the 25<sup>th</sup> birthday (if the patient was 17 years when treatment was finished, keep records until the 26<sup>th</sup> birthday)</li> </ul> |

### ***Patient information***

|                                                     |                                                                                                                                           |
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| Written information to be given to patient or carer | Supply the patient information leaflet (PIL) provided with the medication.                                                                |
| Follow-up advice to be given to patient or carer    | To seek medical advice if symptoms worsen rapidly or significantly, do not improve in 3–4 weeks, or they become systemically very unwell. |

### **Key references**

- NICE Medicines Practice Guideline 2 (MPG2): Patient Group Directions. Published March 2017 <https://www.nice.org.uk/guidance/mpg2>
- NICE MPG2 Patient group directions: competency framework for health professionals using patient group directions. Updated March 2017 <https://www.nice.org.uk/guidance/mpg2/resources>
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- British National Formulary (BNF) Key information on the selection, prescribing, dispensing and administration of medicines [BNF \(British National Formulary\) | NICE](#)
- Summary of Product Characteristics

### **Agreement to practise by the Registered Healthcare Professional**

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| Name and address of pharmacy premises / clinic premises to which this PGD relates |           |                     |           |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|---------------------|-----------|
|                                                                                   |           |                     |           |
| Name of healthcare professional                                                   | Job title | Registration number | Signature |
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**PGD adoption and authorisation by the employer/clinical lead**

The employer has ensured that the person using this PGD, has the knowledge and skills to safely provide the service which will encompass the supply or administration of a medication or vaccine.

This section must be signed by the superintendent or clinical lead responsible for this service.

| Name of superintendent / clinical lead | Job title & name of organisation | Signature | Date |
|----------------------------------------|----------------------------------|-----------|------|
|                                        |                                  |           |      |

Name of professional group  
signatory

Job title & name of  
organisation

Signature

Date

### Signed on behalf of Get Real Health

| Name             | Qualification                  | Signature                                                                          | Date      |
|------------------|--------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| Nitin Shori      | Medical Doctor<br>GMC: 6047293 |                                                                                    | 25/8/2025 |
| Chris Pilkington | Pharmacist<br>GPhC: 2046322    |  | 25/8/2025 |

### Change history

| Version number | Change details                 | Date                       |
|----------------|--------------------------------|----------------------------|
| 001            | Development & issue of new PGD | 25 <sup>th</sup> June 2025 |
|                |                                |                            |
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Patient Group Direction  
for the administration of Varilrix for the treatment of Chickenpox

# Patient Group Direction

for the supply/administration of

*Varilrix*

for vaccination against

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| Legal category                              | POM                                                                                                                                              |
| Storage                                     | Store in a refrigerator (2°C–8°C). Do not freeze. Protect from light.                                                                            |
| Route/method of administration              | Subcutaneous or intramuscular injection.                                                                                                         |
| Dose and frequency                          | 0.5 mL dose. A second dose may be administered at least 6 weeks after the first if required.                                                     |
| Quantity to be administered and/or supplied | 0.5ml dose                                                                                                                                       |
| Maximum or minimum treatment period         | One or two doses depending on age and immune status.                                                                                             |
| Adverse effects                             | Injection site reactions, fever, rash, irritability. Rare: febrile seizures, varicella-like rash. Refer to SmPC for full adverse effect profile. |

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|                                        |                                  |           |      |

Name of professional group  
signatory

Job title & name of  
organisation

Signature

Date

**Signed on behalf of Get Real Health**

| Name             | Qualification                  | Signature                                                                          | Date      |
|------------------|--------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| Nitin Shori      | Medical Doctor<br>GMC: 6047293 |                                                                                    | 25/8/2025 |
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